on the deal. Assistant Secretary of State Philips Talbot confirmed that, in that case, the US would not offer India an air package.[150]

Indian policymakers were aware that the purchase from Moscow was a stumbling block for a US-India deal, but they were not going to give up the Soviet option. The MiG deal was a bird in hand; moreover, they did not want to be overly dependent on the US as a military supplier. Senior Indian policymakers told Bowles that they already felt pressured by the US on a number of fronts. Delhi believed that diversifying its dependence at least gave India the ability to resist that pressure somewhat. Furthermore, even if Shastri had wanted to put all India's eggs in one basket, domestic political circumstances would have made it hard for him to renege on the MiG deal. Politically, he was vulnerable from the left flank of the Congress Party, which had opposed his coming to power. He was also sensitive to criticism that he was deviating from Nehru's foreign policy and had to push back against such accusations. When Bowles worried about the impact of the Soviet deal on implementation and extension of the American MoU, Shastri said that the MiG deal had been a Nehru decision in April 1964 and he would not withdraw from it.[151]

On the US side, domestic politics made it unlikely that an India that agreed to a Soviet deal would also be able to get much greater American military assistance. As it was, Johnson had been concerned that any major military aid package to India would affect congressional sentiments about the large economic assistance package India was receiving.[152] Once it became evident that India was taking the MiG option, administration officials expected a negative reaction in Congress.[153]

Bowles expected that a Soviet military assistance package would mean that Indian policymakers, on their part, would cease further negotiations with the US. As a State Department India specialist predicted, however, Delhi had no desire to put all its eggs in the Soviet basket.[154] For one, Indian policymakers were not convinced that Beijing and Moscow would remain at odds. Bowles indeed tried to encourage such doubts about Soviet reliability versus China in the minds of Shastri and Chavan, indicating that Sino-Soviet rapprochement remained a key Soviet goal.[155] India also doubted Soviet reliability in terms of Moscow's ability to deliver. This led to Chavan approaching the US again in early 1965 to assess its willingness to supply India with F-5s. The State Department received intelligence that